Case Consult: Leo's Story

Sunday School worksheet. Bible Lesson: Doctrine of Atonement, October 12 to 18, 2026.

How this works

Social workers use a case consult to take a hard situation one step at a time. We break the story into pieces, look at who is involved, and ask two questions at each step: what are the practical next moves, and what is needed to see this person clearly? Today we use the same method on a real family's story, with one added lens: what is true spiritually at each step. Names and details have been changed.
For each vignette, fill in two columns.

- **Human footsteps:** the practical, visible steps people took or could take. Think phone calls, forms, questions, notes, rides, translation, and listening.
- **Spiritualized thought:** what is true of Leo, and of everyone in the story, as God's child, plus the idea from this week's lesson that helps you hold it.

Who is in the story

- Leo, a man who has just arrived with his wife and needs medical care.
- Leo's wife.
- Their children.
- Mia, Leo's daughter-in-law, a social worker who helps the family find their way through the medical system.
- The doctors, geneticists, and counselors who cared for Leo along the way.

Ground rules

- Everyone in this story is held in Love: Leo, his family, the medical team, and the other families at the clinic. There are no villains here.
- No blame. Nobody did anything wrong to cause this.
- Your family may handle health differently than Leo's family did. That is welcome here. Love does not play favorites among paths.
- A spiritualized thought is not a prediction or a promise about an outcome. It is what we choose to hold as true while we act.

Anchor idea

"Atonement is the exemplification of man's unity with God, whereby man reflects divine Truth, Life, and Love." (Science and Health, 18:1–3) Atonement means at-one-ment. Keep this sentence in front of you as you work through the vignettes.

Vignette 1: Building a Care Team

What happened	Human footsteps	Spiritualized thought
Leo and his wife have just arrived, and the family's first goal is to set up care for him: a primary care doctor, then a nephrologist (a kidney specialist). Leo is uncomfortable in the medical world, and English is a second language for him and his wife. Mia, his daughter-in-law, is a social worker, so she knows the forms, the questions to ask, and how to take notes that make sense later. Leo and Mia pray in different traditions. They have come to treasure that.		

Lesson passages to explore

- Matthew 14:14: "And Jesus went forth, and saw a great multitude, and was moved with compassion toward them."
- Science and Health, 15:26–27: "Self-forgetfulness, purity, and affection are constant prayers."

Talk it over. Leo is uncomfortable in the medical world, and the doctors do not speak his language. What would help you feel safe in that room?

Vignette 2: A Name Arrives

What happened	Human footsteps	Spiritualized thought
The nephrologist asks for genetic testing, and the testing is done. The result comes back as a rare genetic condition. The family now has a name for what they are facing.		

Lesson passages to explore

- Jeremiah 31:3: "Yea, I have loved thee with an everlasting love."
- Science and Health, 333:26–27: "The divine image, idea, or Christ was, is, and ever will be inseparable from the divine Principle, God."
- Golden Text, Isaiah 61:10 (NRSV): "he has clothed me with the garments of salvation."

Talk it over. A diagnosis gives a condition a name. Does the name tell you who Leo is? What does?

Vignette 3: Where It Came From

What happened	Human footsteps	Spiritualized thought
The family meets with a geneticist, who traces the condition back through the family's history and explains how it was most likely passed down.		

Lesson passages to explore

- John 3:17: "God sent not his Son into the world to condemn the world; but that the world through him might be saved."
- Science and Health, 31:10: "He recognized Spirit, God, as the only creator, and therefore as the Father of all."

Talk it over. When something is hard, people look for someone to blame. What changes when we choose not to condemn anyone, including ourselves? How would you want a family to be treated when its history comes up in a doctor's office?

Vignette 4: Research Across a Language Gap

What happened	Human footsteps	Spiritualized thought
Mia reads as much of the medical research as she can find. Leo and his wife cannot take part in this work because of the language barrier. Mia then finds a nonprofit patient organization for the condition and learns that it is holding a clinic in another city.		

Lesson passages to explore

- Hebrews 10:24: "let us consider one another to provoke unto love and to good works."
- Science and Health, 202:3: "The scientific unity which exists between God and man must be wrought out in life-practice."
- Science and Health, page 18: Jesus came "to show them how to do theirs, but not to do it for them nor to relieve them of a single responsibility."

Talk it over. Mia did the reading because Leo and his wife could not. Where is the line between serving someone and doing it for them? How would you keep Leo in charge of his own story?

Vignette 5: The Clinic

What happened	Human footsteps	Spiritualized thought
Mia takes Leo to the clinic, and the family learns a great deal about the genes involved. The genetic counselor trusts the test, but this exact variation in Leo's gene is new to her. It has not appeared in clinical studies, so no one can say what it will mean or when. She describes a fully working protein as a six-foot wall and says Leo's is built most of the way up, much further than most people with this condition. She is clear that "milder" is a working hypothesis, not a finding. The family also sees some very sick children. The doctor's advice is to be grateful, to thank God, and to let the clinic test the family. The family wants to help toward a cure.		

Lesson passages to explore

- Psalm 18:28: "the Lord my God will enlighten my darkness."
- Job 32:8: "There is a spirit in man: and the inspiration of the Almighty giveth them understanding."
- Revelation 7:9, 17: "a great multitude, which no man could number, of all nations, and kindreds, and people, and tongues," and "God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes."
- Science and Health, 340:12: "Divine Love is infinite. Therefore all that really exists is in and of God, and manifests His love."

Talk it over. What is the difference between a hypothesis and a verdict? How can "not knowing" still be held in God's care? What does compassion ask of us when we meet children who are very sick?

Vignette 6: The Road Ahead

What happened	Human footsteps	Spiritualized thought
The guidance is for Leo to be vigilant about several areas of his health, with a specialist for each, starting with one. His children may carry the same gene change, and the clinic recommends that they be tested. The family hopes to help the search for a cure.		

Lesson passages to explore

- Science and Health, 170:14–15: "The demands of Truth are spiritual, and reach the body through Mind."
- Hebrews 10:23, 24: "Let us hold fast the profession of our faith without wavering," and "let us consider one another to provoke unto love and to good works."
- Science and Health, 22:11–12: "'Work out your own salvation,' is the demand of Life and Love, for to this end God worketh with you."
- Psalm 139:7: "Whither shall I go from thy spirit?"

Talk it over. The doctors used the word "vigilance." Watching can come from love or from fear. How does each one feel, for the person being watched and for the family doing the watching?

Putting it together

1. Look back over your six rows. Where did Love show up as action?
2. Atonement means at-one-ment. Two people from different traditions sat in one room, held by one Love. What does unity look like when two people pray differently?
3. Some people would say, "Just don't go to the doctor," and that is a strong stand. Mia chose to show up where Leo was. How can we hold both choices with equal respect?
4. Write one sentence you could carry into any hospital or waiting room.